

CRATER THE CUP

REPRESENTING THE DRINKING CUP OF THE GREEK GOD APOLLO, CRATER IS USUALLY DEPICTED AS A DOUBLE-HANDLED CHALICE. FAINT AND INDISTINCT, THIS CONSTELLATION MAY BE MORE EASILY LOCATED IF IMAGINED AS A LARGE BOW TIE IN THE SKY.

One of the original 48 constellations from Greek mythology, Crater's story links it with its neighboring constellations Corvus (the crow) and Hydra (the water snake). Apollo is said to have placed the three together in the sky. He was angered that the crow not only was slow to return from a water-collecting trip, but then lied that the water snake had prevented him from collecting any water.

Crater has no brilliant stars, the brightest being Delta, at magnitude 3.6. A large telescope is needed to see any deep-sky objects, such as the barred spiral galaxy NGC 3981. This and galaxies NGC 3511 and NGC 3887 were discovered by British astronomer William Herschel in the mid-1780s. Much more distant, about 6 billion light-years from Earth, is the quasar RXJ 1131.

KEY DATA

Size ranking	53
Brightest stars	Delta (δ) 3.6, Alkes (α) 4.1
Genitive	Crateris
Abbreviation	Crt
Highest in sky at 10pm	April
Fully visible	65°N–90°S



CHART 5

MAIN STARS

Alkes Alpha (α) Crateris
Orange giant

☼ 4.1 ↔ 159 light-years

Delta (δ) Crateris
Orange giant

☼ 3.6 ↔ 195 light-years

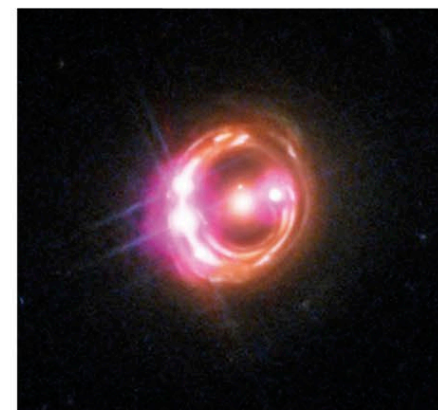
DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 3511
Barred spiral galaxy

NGC 3887
Barred spiral galaxy

NGC 3981
Barred spiral galaxy

RXJ 1131
Quasar powered by a supermassive black hole



△ RXJ 1131

The four pink dots in this image are the quasar RXJ 1131. The multiple images are the result of the quasar's light being bent by an elliptical galaxy. That galaxy, seen in the center, is on the same line of sight as RXJ 1131 but is much closer to us.

Delta (δ) Crateris
Lying 195 light-years away, this star is an orange giant and, at magnitude 3.6, the brightest in Crater

Gamma (γ) Crateris
A white binary star that shines at magnitude 4.1. Its companion can be discerned through a small telescope

Alkes (α Crateris)
An orange giant of magnitude 4.1. Its name is derived from the Arabic for "cup"

NGC 3511
A barred spiral galaxy tilted almost edge-on to Earth

